



NAVAL CANNON

The barrels of cannon used at sea differed little from those used on land until the 19th century, although carriages for naval service were often more compact. Naval cannon were either cast in bronze or built by forging together pieces of wrought iron (see p.12), until cast iron was perfected in the late 16th century. Bronze was an expensive material, but very durable and impervious to corrosion, unlike iron. Decorative elements could be easily added to the pattern from which a bronze cannon would be cast, and many bronze cannon were decorated ornately. Wrought-iron cannon were relatively plain because wrought iron was a difficult material to embellish.



▲ BRONZE FALCON WITH 10-SIDED BARREL

Date c.1520

Origin England or Flanders

Length 9ft (2.78m)

Caliber 2.6in (66mm)

This falcon was cast by a Flemish master gun-founder for King Henry VIII of England as part of a consignment of 28 guns. It fired balls of lead weighing 2¼lb (1kg).



Octagonal barrel

▲ BRONZE FALCON

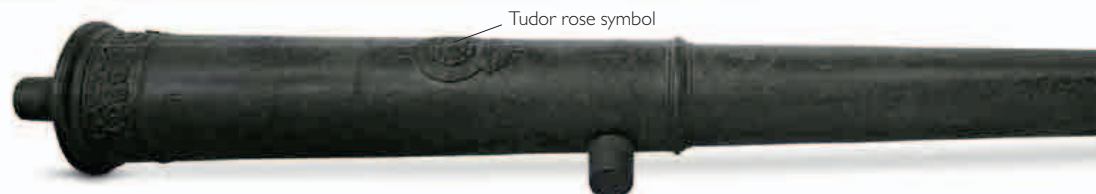
Date c.1520

Origin Flanders or France

Length 8¼ft (2.5m)

Caliber 2.5in (63mm)

The falcon was a light cannon typical of the early 16th century. This model was ordered by Henry VIII, possibly from Flanders, because England did not have an established gun-manufacturing industry at the time.



Tudor rose symbol

▲ BRONZE SAKER

Date 1529

Origin England

Length 7¼ft (2.23m)

Caliber 3.75in (95mm)

Like many early guns, the Saker was named after a bird of prey—in this case, the Saker falcon. This one was acquired from an Italian master craftsman as part of Henry VIII's campaign to supply English forces with artillery of the best quality.

Winged mermaid (facing outward)



Figure of wyvern (mythical dragonlike creature)

▲ BRONZE ROBINET

Date 1535

Origin France

Length 7¾ft (2.39m)

Caliber 1.7in (43mm)

This is an extremely ornate example of the robinet, a light cannon with a small caliber and a barrel weighing a little more than 400lb (181kg). This model was made in Metz, France. It was seized in Paris in 1815 by troops of the Seventh Coalition (Prussia, Russia, Austria, and Great Britain) fighting Napoleon's forces.



Tiller



Trunnion

Wrought-iron band around barrel

▲ IRON BREECH-LOADING SWIVEL GUN

Date 16th century

Origin Europe

Length 5¼ft (1.63m)

Caliber 3in (76mm)

Pivots that allowed a gun to fire across a wide arc turned a fixed barrel into a swivel gun (see p.14), especially useful aboard a ship when firing on moving vessels. This type was used in an antipersonnel role, shooting stone ammunition.

▲ BRONZE MINION

Date c.1550

Origin Italy

Length 8¼ft (2.5m)

Caliber 3in (76mm)

Minions, light cannon that were particularly well adapted for use at sea, saw service on many English ships during their engagement with the Spanish Armada (1588).